During the rest of the Johnson administration, American and Indian policymakers came to the conclusion that the relationship was not as worthwhile as it had been in the past. And with that came less incentive and less desire for significant engagement.

Losing Traction

The Indian reaction, the potential adverse impact on Indian economic reforms and the elections, and support from other countries eventually led Johnson to approve the suggested interim allocation in January 1967. He also recommended that Congress—as a "vital act of democratic affirmation"—aid India further and urged multilateralizing food aid.[140]

Rostow had noted that Johnson's approach on food aid had been "popular at home" and "educational abroad."[141] It certainly was educational to India, but not in a good way. The experience shook Gandhi, as did the Indian election results that March. The Congress Party remained in power, but it suffered a serious setback, with Gandhi acknowledging the results as "very bad."[142] Congress went from 73 percent of the seats in the Lok Sabha to 55 percent. In the state assemblies, it went from holding 61 percent of the seats to 49 percent.[143]

Adding to the government's challenge was the continuing China threat. The foreign minister publicly stressed that it was "a great menace to India and to all Southeast Asian countries."[144] The year before, it had conducted another nuclear test. Moreover, Thimphu had complained about Chinese intrusions in "the Doklam pastures" at the Bhutan-China-India trijunction. India had also started feeling the effects of the Cultural Revolution in China, with cross-border propaganda encouraging Indian soldiers to revolt and Red Guards desecrating Sikh temples in China.[145]

Privately, Jagat Singh Mehta, the policy-planning chief, noted that, whatever internal changes might be taking place in China, "As far as India is concerned, the attitude remains the same—of hostility and promotion of dislocation and chaos."[146] Most policymakers did not think China would engage in a full-scale war with India, but they expected pressure on the border, occasional intrusions, and border skirmishes, as well as—most significantly—subversion.[147]

Concern about subversion increased with the greater sense of political vulnerability, made evident at the polls. The results were seen as a reflection